THE BASICS – BEGINNING TO USE A COMPUTER

THE WINDOWS DESKTOP

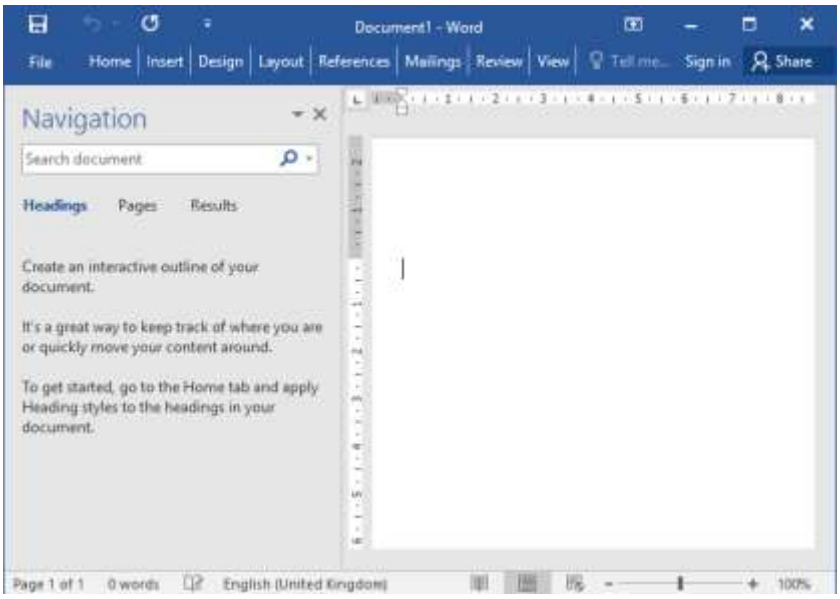
You interact with a computer through a **User Interface.** Personal computers nowadays use a Graphical User Interface (GUI), which is an interface between a user and a computer system that involves the use of a mouse-controlled screen cursor to select options from menus, make choices with buttons and start programs by clicking icons. An icon is symbol or graphic representation on a screen of a program, option, or window. It is a picture that represents an application, a file or other system resource (e.g. a printer). On this interface, pictures, graphics and menus represent the choices available to you. You use a **pointer** to select the action that you want to carry out.

Definition of terms:

Desktop: The area of a display screen where images, windows, icons and other graphical items such as dialogue boxes appear. This is the main screen display on a personal computer, from which windows may be opened and programs run and is the first screen you will see when the computer starts up.



Windows: A window is a separate viewing area on a computer display screen in a system that allows multiple viewing areas as part of a graphical user interface It is a frame on the screen in which application program is run. An application must be open in a window before it can run. A window can usually be resized by the user. For example, it can be stretched on any side, minimized, maximized, and closed.

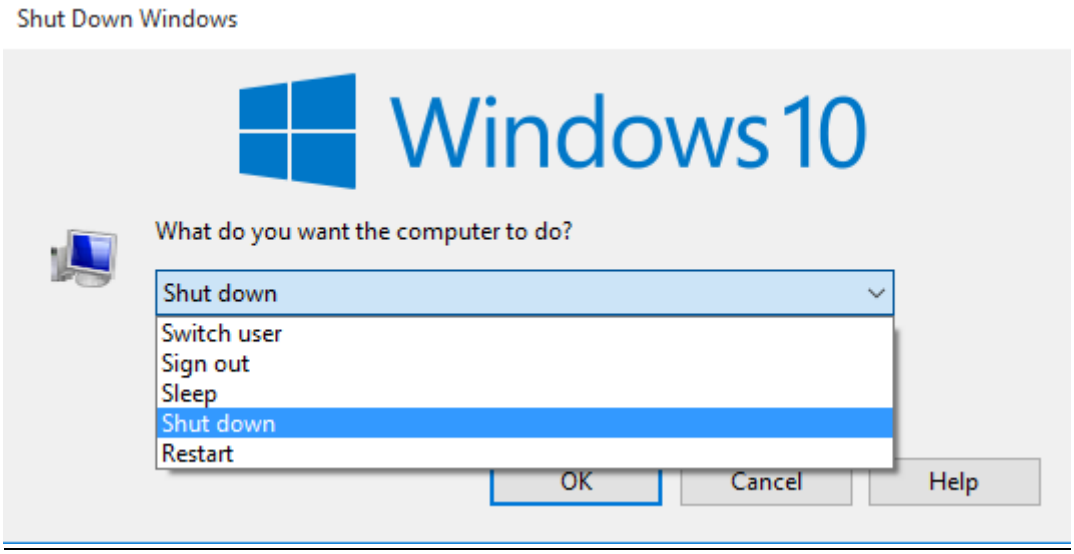


Taskbar: A taskbar is an element of a graphical user interface which typically shows which programs are currently running. It contains Start button, buttons for each open application and other information. (e.g. time).

Start button: The Start button allows users to access their computer programs or configure Microsoft Windows easily by accessing the Start Menu. clicking on this button opens the **Start** menu which gives you access to all applications, and other facilities such as **Control Panel, PC Settings** and **Shut Down** command.

Shortcut: A **desktop shortcut**, usually represented by an icon, is a small file that points to a program, folder, document, or Internet location. Clicking on a **shortcut** icon takes you directly to the object to which the **shortcut** points. **Shortcut** icons contain a small arrow in their lower left corner. It gives quick access to frequently used programs so that you do not need to look through menus each time you use it.

Dialoq box: A **dialog box** is a user interface element. It is a type of **window** that is used to enable communication and interaction between a user and a software program. It is a window that opens on-screen to provide information about the current action or to ask the user to provide additional information to complete the action.



Menus: Menus are sets of options presented to the user of a computer application to help the user find information or execute a program function. These are lists of action that can be carried out in a particular application. You also may have sub-menus cascading from the main menu.



Mouse Pointer: A mouse pointer, also known as a mouse arrow, or mouse cursor, is a graphical image that is used to activate or control certain elements in a GUI. It is a symbol (usually an arrow that is used to indicate the current location of the mouse.

On screen, the mouse pointer moves with the movements of the mouse on your desk. Unless otherwise specified, you use the left mouse button for all mouse actions.

Basic mouse actions:

Click – A click is the act of pressing a computer mouse button once without moving the mouse. To click, you point to an item, then press and quickly release the left mouse button. You click to select an item. To cancel a selection, you click an empty area of the desktop.

Double Click - Double-click is a term used to describe the process of quickly pressing a mouse button twice while keeping it still. To double-click, you point to an item, then press and quickly release the left mouse button twice as quickly as possible. You double click to open or close a window or start applications from icons.

Right Click – Most computer mice have at least two mouse buttons. When you press the left one, it is called a left click or a click. When you press the one on the right, it is called a right click. You click the right mouse button to open a pop-up context menu, which gives you shortcuts to frequently used commands. To close this menu, click the left mouse button outside the menu.

Drag - In computer graphical user interfaces, drag and drop is a pointing device gesture in which the user selects a virtual object by "grabbing" it and dragging it to a different location or onto another virtual object. To drag and drop an item, you point to the item, then press and hold down the left mouse button as you move the pointer to another location and then release the mouse button. You drag to resize or move windows and icons or to scroll.

MENUS AND ICONS

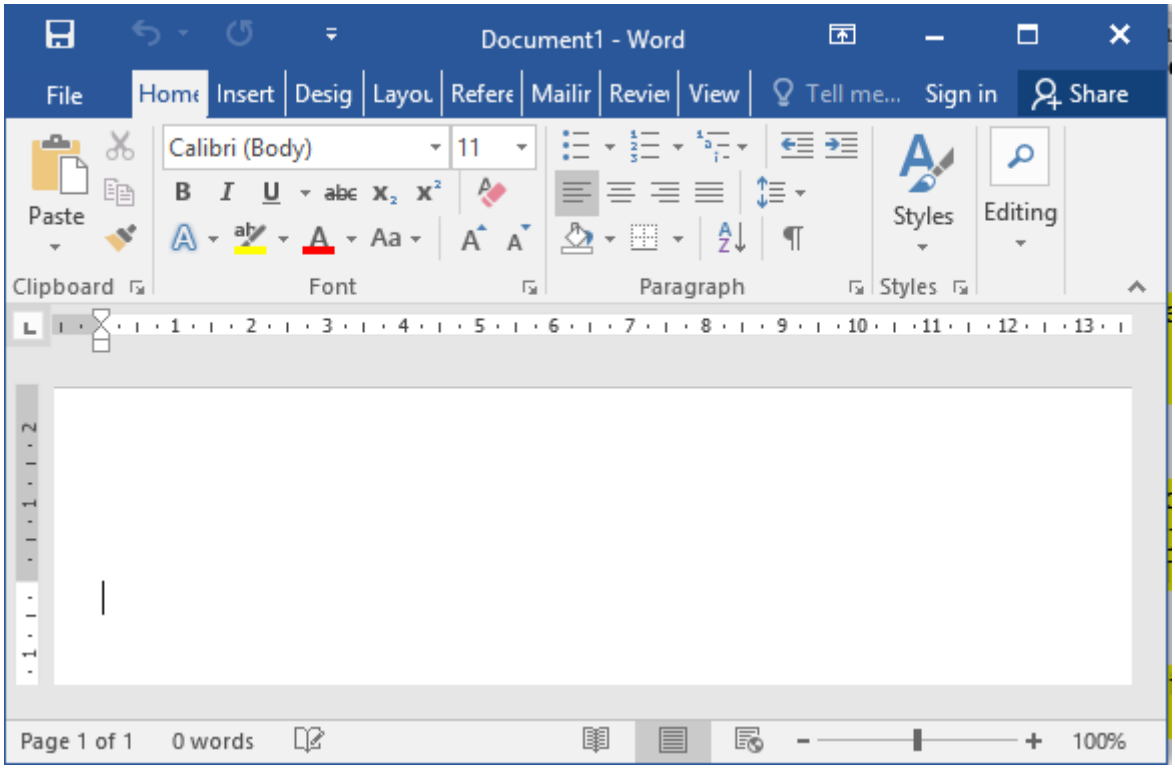
To open applications, programs or facilities on Windows, click on the appropriate icon on the Desktop or you can open them through the Start menu.

Understanding the Start Menu

The Start menu is a graphical user interface element used in Microsoft Windows since Windows 95 and in some other operating systems. It provides a central launching point for computer programs and performing other tasks. The Start button gives you access to all available applications and other facilities. When Start menu is open, moving the mouse pointer moves a selection bar through all of the menu options. When the selection menu highlights a selection bar with a right facing triangle, a sub-menu opens. Click on the appropriate selection to start an application.

Working with Windows
In Windows, applications, documents, dialog boxes open in a window. All windows have the same structure and work in the same way.

BASIC ELEMENTS OF A WINDOW



The title bar is a bar located at the top of a window or a dialog box that displays the name of the window or software program being used as well as the Minimize, Maximize and Close buttons. By dragging the title bar, you can move the window around the screen.

Minimize Button - The button in all GUI operating systems that hides a window but keeps the application running and accessible in the background. The window appears as a button on the Task Bar. Note this does not close the window - it just reduces it to the Task Bar. To restore a window again, click on this button in the Task Bar

Maximize Button – Maximize allows the user to enlarge a window, usually making it fill the entire screen or the program window in which it is contained. When a window is maximized, this button changes to the Restore button. Click the Restore button to restore the window to its previous size.

Close Button – This button closes the window.

Window Frame – The Window Frame identifies the edges of the window. The edges can be dragged to change the size of edges of the window. The cursor will change to a double-headed arrow when placed over the edge. Dragging at a corner resizes the window two sides at a time.

Menu Bar – The menu bar in Microsoft Windows is usually anchored to the top of a window under the title bar. It gives you access to the application's menus, enabling you to select options that perform functions or carry out commands.

Scroll Bar – A vertical or horizontal bar commonly located on the far right or bottom of a window that allows you to move the window viewing area up, down, left, or right. Click on the arrows, or drag the scroll bar to perform this action.

Status Bar - A status bar is a horizontal window at the bottom of a parent window in which an application can display various kinds of status information.

WORKING WITH MULTIPLE WINDOWS

You can open more than one window at a time and arrange them on your Desktop just as you would arrange papers on your desk. You can adjust the size and position of your windows using the methods described earlier, or you can use the **Tile** and **Cascade** options to arrange your windows. Cascading places one window behind the other (with the title bar showing). Tiling arranges the windows in a tile pattern over the desktop.

To arrange windows using Cascade:

1. Open the windows you are working with
2. Move to the **Taskbar** and **right click** the mouse on the empty space, away from application buttons.
3. Choose Cascade windows

To arrange windows Horizontally:

- Open the windows you are working with
- Move to the **Taskbar** and **right click** the mouse on the empty space, away from application buttons.
- Choose Show windows stacked

To arrange windows Vertically:

- Open the windows you are working with
- Move to the **Taskbar** and **right click** the mouse on the empty space, away from application buttons.
- Choose Show windows side by side

WORKING WITH FILE AND FOLDERS

Each piece of work that you produce on a computer is called a **file**. Files are usually stored on the hard drive within the computer (the C: drive) or on a flash disk. You can open files stored on a flash disk from any other compatible computer (as long as you put the disk into USB port). If you store files on the hard drive of a computer, they can only be used again from that particular computer.

MANAGING FILE AND FOLDERS

When you have been using computers for a while, you will have many stored files. To organize your work effectively, you need to store files in **folders**. Computer folders work in a similar way to paper folders.

We will use Windows Explorer to describe file and folder management operations.

To start Windows Explorer

- Right-click on the **Start** button
- Click on **Windows Explorer**

Or

Click on the File Explorer icon on the Task bar.

Windows Explorer is the file manager used by **Windows** 95 and later versions. It allows users to manage files, folders and network connections, as well as search for files and related components. Note that this screen is split into two segments: the left-hand side of the screen displays icons representing the folder structure of the disk drives on the computer, and the right-hand side shows the files (and other folders) in a selected folder.

Viewing the contents of disk drive and folder

To view the contents of a disk drive

- Select the required drive on the left-hand side of the screen.

The right-hand screen will change to show of the contents of the selected drive. On the left-hand side of the screen, some of the folders are prefixed with either a › or ⌄ arrow.

› Indicates there are sub-folders within this folder. Clicking on the › expands the levels and displays the details of the lower folders.

⌄ Indicates that there are no more levels (i.e. sub-folders) within these folders. Clicking on the '⌄' collapses the folder, hiding any levels that had appeared below it.

To open a folder a folder

- Click on the folder name on the left-hand side of the screen. A folder will automatically close when another folder is selected. Only one folder can be open at any one time.

  The contents of a folder can be displayed either as **Icons**, as a **List of folders and filenames** or the **File details**

To select the required option

- Choose **View**
- Choose the required option (i.e. Extra large icons, Large icons, Medium-sized icons, Small Icons, List, Details, Tiles, Content)

To change the order in which files are displayed.

- Choose **View**,
- Choose **Sort by**
- Select the order in which the files are to be displayed – (by Name. Date modified, Type, Size, Date Created, Authors, Categories, Tags, Titles, Ascending or Descending).

CREATING FOLDERS

New files are created within the current or active folder.

To create a folder

- Select the appropriate disk or folder.
- Choose **Home**,
- Choose **New Folder**.
- Type a name for the new folder
- Press the Enter key

DELETING FOLDERS

Deleting a folder deletes all the files and sub-folders contained within the folder.

To delete a folder

- Select the folder you wish to delete.
- From the menu choose **Home**
- Select Delete icon from the tool bar.

Alternatively, select the folder and press the **Delete key** on the keyboard.

SELECTING FILES

To select One file – click on the file name with the left mouse button

To select a continuous group of files

- Select the first file in the list with the mouse.
- Press and hold down the **Shift** key on the keyboard
- Click on the last file required. All files between these two points should be highlighted.

To select a non-continuous group of files

- Select the first file in the list with the mouse.
- Press and hold down the **Ctrl** key on the keyboard
- Click on any additional files required. Only the files selected should be highlighted.

COPYING FILES

To copy files

- Select the files you want to copy
- Choose **Home,**
- Choose **Copy**.
- Select the destination folder
- Choose **Home**, **Paste**.

MOVING FILES

Moving files can be achieved following the same procedures as above using **Home**, **Cut** instead of **Home, Copy**.

DELETING FILES

Files that are deleted are normally sent to the Recycle bin.

To delete files

- Select the files you wish to delete
- Choose **Home**,
- Choose **Delete** icon from the toolbar, or press the **Delete** key on the keyboard.

EDIT UNDO

If you make a mistake, the Undo command allows you to reverse the last file operation carried out.

- Click the Undo icon on the Quick Access Toolbar. This command will continue to reverse operations until the Undo icon is dimmed.